between batting or bowling – which dominated my game after that early peak in performance in 1996, I had a distinct playing style. Once I lost it, I never really got it back. I have a particularly aggressive individual talent that I should have developed and polished and not played the game the way everybody else played it. And I wish I'd been coached by someone who would have used my original, natural skill set and done something with it, instead of trying to turn me into a traditional player from an era I don't know much about and never belonged to.

Still, I soldiered on and had my share of ups and downs. The larger plan to keep going was built on the motivation I got from my trusted friends and family. They knew me better than I knew myself, at times. They knew I still had some cricket left in me. Most importantly, they knew I could do more.

That's when I eventually turned things around for some famous comebacks. I like comebacks. Otherwise, I know there were at least two times in my career when I gave away my cricket gear to friends. But my wife, my brothers and, before he passed away, my father, insisted that I continue to play on. It's all I was good at, my father would say. One of us is going to be a great name, he would tell my siblings and me, when we were kids. Even after his death, I doubt if it was me he was referring to.

As for those multiple retirements which have so often been criticized, questioned and even been made the butt of jokes – a commonly heard one was that I retired as many times as I got Man of the Match awards – well, they happened because my emotions got the better of me. When I wanted to play Tests, the powers-that-be wouldn't let me. When I made it to the Test level, they pulled me out of ODIs. When I concentrated and did well in ODIs, they dropped me from the Test team. Obviously, I reacted.

In hindsight, I can say I overreacted. I didn't accept the team selection decisions rationally and on being dropped and moved around so often, announced my retirement prematurely, even rashly. I did it again and then again. Bad moves, all of them. But I should've known: I was too passionate to quit. That's why I kept coming back. Thankfully, I was also passionate enough to not play any political games with the board or in matters of being selected.

My unorthodox style of playing and the complications it caused me, personally and professionally, are life lessons. Time is a teacher. It teaches you patience. It shows you where you went wrong. The good things you keep; the bad things you discard. So, even someone who is naturally aggressive like me ends up learning how to control the aggression, harnesses it and channels it in a better way. Sometimes, it's too late. And sometimes, like it happened at the 2009 World T20, it comes at the perfect time.

Thus, my batting is like my life. A bad innings is like a bad episode with friends who are not really friends. You make a mistake, you get out, you try to learn and move on. An evolved human being, in my opinion, is one who learns with time.

To address the most common criticism levelled against me, a lack of technique, I must point out that a lot of top cricketers lack classic orthodox technique and they still do just fine. There are also plenty of batsmen with conventional technique but they don't have the variety in shots that guys like me do.

God doesn't make anybody perfect. I'm grateful for what He has given me in terms of talent. I didn't even imagine that I'd play for over 20 years for Pakistan, serve my country doing what I love – playing cricket.